Westbrook School Committee

~ School Committee Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, March 11, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 117 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1172728940
Packet: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1hJDHbQj_aXGU6qL6FyDXCCPps4XzE5ev/view (Google Drive, via westbrookschools.org)

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *The full committee (all seven members) was present; one student representative (Tina Nguyen) was present and delivered the student report. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Superintendent's Report: State of the Schools

Demographics, Staff & Academics [2:39]

Discussion Summary

Dr. Lancia delivered the district's annual State of the Schools presentation (a 60-plus page report posted online), built around this year's theme, “I Belong Here.” As of January 2026, the district serves 2,377 students pre-K through grade 12: 27% in special education (highest share in Cumberland County), 26% multilingual, 3% McKinney-Vento homeless-eligible, and 59% meeting federal low-income guidelines. The district has 496 employees (six positions unfilled). Special education now serves 609 students, up 13 from last year and a 70% increase over the past decade; the Director of Special Education Services position has been vacant all year after two unsuccessful searches. The multilingual program serves 588 students (up 60), with strong ACCESS assessment growth districtwide.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational presentation.

Action Items

None.

Facilities, Technology & Community [22:40]

Discussion Summary

FY26's $53.35 million budget was a lean “maintenance” budget; per-pupil spending ($21,135) is fourth-lowest in Cumberland County. The district's solar project is generating at Congin and Saccarappa, with the middle school and high school to follow this spring/summer, projected to save about $305,000 annually once complete (a separate figure from the $279,000 Siemens energy-efficiency savings reported March 4). All school kitchens are now halal-certified, and School Nutrition Director Mary Emerson was named Maine's Nutrition Director of the Year for 2025. The district relaunched the Westbrook Education Foundation and welcomed a new WHS

Alumni Association this year.

Dr. Lancia noted a decrease in chronic absenteeism this year, cautioning that next year's comparison may differ because some students were kept home earlier this year out of fear tied to immigration enforcement; he credited a community-volunteer response during that period and noted the district has since refined its own immigration-enforcement response plan alongside its existing safety protocols.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational presentation.

Action Items

None.

Board Discussion: Assessments, Per-Pupil Spending & State Funding [01:04:04]

Discussion Summary

Member Erin Cavallaro asked whether state assessments account for a student's first language; Dr. Lancia explained multilingual students get only a one-time exemption from the English language arts test, and that the district relies more on the separate ACCESS assessment to gauge real multilingual progress. Chair Mancuso asked how the district's low per-pupil spending interacts with its unusually complex student population; Dr. Lancia described a deliberately lean, needs-based budget that still tries to remove financial barriers to opportunity even as class sizes creep upward. Dr. Flynn Ross noted the seeming paradox that Westbrook's rising property valuation has simultaneously reduced the district's federal and state funding support. Dr. Lancia reported meeting with Governor Mills the day before to discuss federal funding challenges and a newly proposed state funding formula.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — informational presentation.

Action Items

None.

Old & New Business

11.1–11.6 — Six School Department Policy Actions, Final Approval (Taken in the Aggregate) [01:24:36]

Discussion Summary

The same six policy actions first approved February 11 — adopt Policy BID (School Committee Member Compensation), approve Policy EHB, EHB–R2, and EHB–R3, and delete Policy EHB–L and EHB–LR — received final approval as a bloc.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 7–0, moved by Noreen Poitras, seconded by Erin Cavallaro.

Action Items

None.

12.1 — Teacher Nomination: Special Education Teacher, Westbrook Middle School

[01:26:17]

Discussion Summary

A nomination to fill a Special Education Teacher vacancy at Westbrook Middle School, replacing a resigned teacher (per the packet: Sarah Hager, replacing Keith Wixson).

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 7–0.

Action Items

None.

12.2 — 2026–27 School Calendar (First Approval) [01:27:18]

Discussion Summary

Staff professional-development days August 27–28, students starting Monday, August 31. No staggered kindergarten/Pre-K start this year — a post-pandemic practice the district is discontinuing after a staff/community survey found strong preference against it, mainly over childcare logistics (78% of staff and 52% of community respondents preferred the calendar presented). The calendar includes 177 student days, two more than Maine's 175-day minimum.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 7–0 (first reading).

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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